

PICTURE PERFECT

With art prices skyrocketing, more and more galleries are now wooing photographers, making photographs the latest collectible whose time has finally come

■ By Nirmala Ravindran

The year 2007 was good for photography in India, but 2008 looks even better. When was the last time that photography was celebrated so much as an art form in our country, when photographers were toasted at wine and cheese evenings

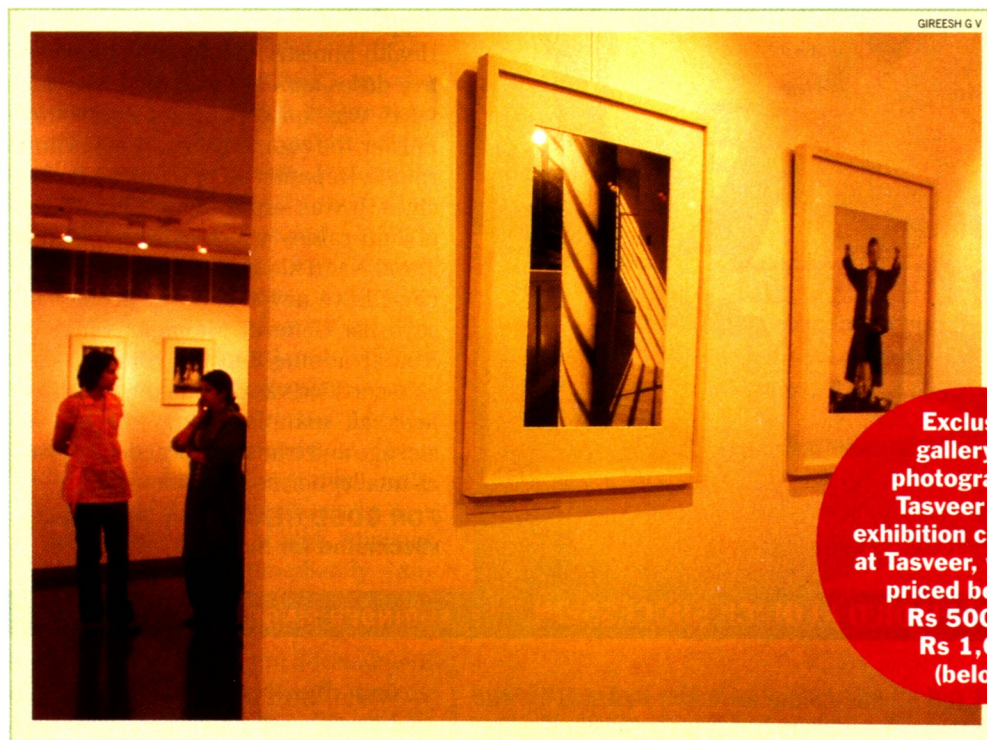
Franck, the Belgian photographer and wife of the legend, the late Henri Cartier Bresson, exhibits at Tasveer in Bangalore, Delhi, Mumbai and Kolkata have witnessed a spate of fantastic works in the last few months. Pablo Bartholomew showed at the National Museum in Delhi, young talents Bharat Sikka and Gauri Gill

So what has really changed? According to Franck, "The biggest difference is that photography is now being perceived as an art form in India and is being commercialised as such and bought by an enlightened public. Till recently it was very much reserved and commissioned by the press, by an elite, or for government projects." Case studies prove her point; and it is not just the big names that are making news. Ravi Prasad, CEO and president of Himalaya, and wife Trupti Prasad bought a 3.5 ftX5 ft photograph of a 23-year-old relatively unknown photographer called Shibu Arakkal in Bangalore in 1999. The single edition cost the Prasads Rs 8,500. Today, nearly nine years later, Arakkal's limited edition prints are priced upwards of Rs 50,000, which is more than five times the original cost, not taking into

account the smaller size or the single edition, as opposed to multiple editions. "We had and still have no clue how much these are valued at, we bought because we liked them," says Trupti.

Others are a bit more selective, choosing to buy photographs as an investment, much like art. "I can't imagine going for an art show, but I'm cool with photographs,"

says new convert, software engineer 35-year-old Shaimak Datta. He is now a collector of sorts, having built up an interesting collection in the last three years, proving the argument behind the cover story in *Fortune* that said investment in (select) photography grew more than stocks, art or bullion, thereby bringing in increased returns on investment. Says Datta, "My collection includes unknown photographers who exhibit in really small places, and I pick up what I like. If they become big names in future, great! If they don't it's perfectly all right, I don't expect the pittance I've



Exclusive gallery for photographs—Tasveer (left); exhibition catalogues at Tasveer, which are priced between Rs 500 and Rs 1,000 (below)

reminiscent of art shows? And, the best thing yet—while it was thus far considered a promotional event (read charity) to show photographs in a gallery, today it makes as much business sense as artistic to woo the new age artist—the hitherto unsung photographer! The writing on the wall is clear—photography, as an art form has come of age, no longer content to just be a tool of documentation, no matter how valued.

While the venerable Martine

showed at Nature Morte. And, if this wasn't impressive enough, the works of Bresson, heritage collection of Ibrahim Alkazi and Sher-Gill collections of Vivan Sundaram were also shown in the capital, with everyone from art lovers and gallerists to buyers flocking to the shows.

graphy grew more than stocks, art or bullion, thereby bringing in increased returns on investment. Says Datta, "My collection includes unknown photographers who exhibit in really small places, and I pick up what I like. If they become big names in

future, great! If they don't it's perfectly all right, I don't expect the pittance I've

